EW 14

85. DEVOIR

A. Meaning `to owe'

I owe him a pound : *Je lui dois une livre*

B To denote COMPULSION or OBLIGATION

The cardinal rule is that *devoir (dû)* is always followed by a present infinitive

If you are translating one of the following English meanings the tense of *devoir* in French will always be the one that is shown:

I am (due) to / I must / I have to	**Je dois**	PRESENT TENSE
I will have to	**Je devrai**	FUTURE TENSE
I was (due) to	**Je devais**	IMPERFECT TENSE
I had to / must (= I used to have to)	**Je devais**	IMPERFECT TENSE
I ought to / I should / would have to	**Je devrais**	CONDITIONAL TENSE
I had to (= completed event)	**J'ai dû / Je dus**	PERFECT / PAST HISTORIC
I had had to	**J'avais dû**	PLUPERFECT TENSE
I would have had to	**J'aurais dû**	CONDITIONAL PERFECT
I ought to have . . .	**J'aurais dû**	CONDITIONAL PERFECT
I should have . . .	**J'aurais dû**	CONDITIONAL PERFECT

Examples:

I am (due) to have dinner with them this evening	:	*Je <u>dois</u> dîner chez eux ce soir*
He was to die the following week	:	*Il <u>devait</u> mourir la semaine suivante*
You ought to go and see him	:	*Vous <u>devriez</u> aller le voir*
I ought to have tried to persuade him	:	*J'<u>aurais dû</u> essayer de le persuader*
He had to do the washing up yesterday	:	*Il <u>a dû</u> faire la vaisselle hier* (completed event)
We always had to leave our shoes outside the door	:	*Nous <u>devions</u> toujours laisser nos chaussures devant la porte* (habitual event)
I should have eaten it	:	*J'<u>aurais dû</u> le manger*
I ought to have eaten it	:	*J'<u>aurais dû</u> le manger*

Note the following refinement

If you are translating "**ought to have been . . .ing**" or "**should have been . . .ing**" you must use the conditional perfect of *devoir* followed by ***en train de* + INFINITIVE**

He ought to have been reading	:	*Il aurait dû être en train de lire*
They should have been thinking about it	:	*Ils auraient dû être en train d'y penser*

C. To denote STRONG PROBABILITY

When translating from English into French (in proses) the above table of meanings will always applyif *devoir* is being used to express obligation. However, a problem arises over the translation of sentences such as these where *devoir* is being used to express strong probability:

You should also complete the pre-test exercises as part of your EW

I haven't got my key. I think I must have dropped it
I didn't have my key. I thought I must have dropped it
He must have been about nineteen
The village must have been about fifteen kilometres away

In the first two examples you will see that "I must have dropped it" appears in both even though the first example is set in the present and the second in the past. The best way to approach these sentences is to imagine them without any notion of probability, discover the tense of the positive statement and apply this tense to *devoir*. **Remember that *devoir* is always followed by an ordinary present infinitive.**

Study the following examples:

I haven't got my key. I think I must have dropped it.
(Imagine : "I haven't got my key. I think I have dropped it", which uses the perfect tense)
→ *Je n'ai pas ma clef. J'ai dû la laisser tomber*

I didn't have my key. I thought I must have dropped it
(Imagine : "I didn't have my key. I thought I had dropped it", which uses the pluperfect tense)
→ *Je n'avais pas ma clef. J'avais dû la laisser tomber*

He must have been about nineteen
(Imagine : "He was about nineteen", which must be imperfect)
→ *Il devait avoir environ dix-neuf ans*

The village must have been about fifteen kilometres away
(Imagine : "The village was about fifteen kilometres away", which must be imperfect
→ *Le village devait être à environ quinze kilomètres*

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86 Some verbs in French require the insertion of *à* before a noun

to give something up	**renoncer à qch**	to obey someone/something	**obéir à qn/qch**
to look like s.o/s.thing	**ressembler à qn/qch**	to disobey someone/something	**désobéir à**
to please someone	**plaire à qn**	to forgive someone	**pardonner à qn**
to expect something	**s'attendre à qch**	to resist someone/something	**résister à**
(nb to expect someone	*attendre qn)*	think of/about	**penser à/ réfléchir à**

- He was thinking about his work : *Il réfléchissait à (pensait à) son travail*
- She looks like her mother : *Elle ressemble à sa mère*
- I wasn't expecting this result : *Je ne m'attendais pas à ce résultat*

When using pronouns with these verbs you must distinguish between PEOPLE and THINGS

i) **referring to things : `it'/`them' = y** [NB there is no past participle agreement after *y*]
- He gave it up : *Il y a renoncé*
- I expected/was expecting it : *Je m'y attendais*

ii) **referring to people**:

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- with non-reflexive verbs except penser: **me, te, lui, nous, vous, leur** (placed BEFORE the verb)

The present pleased him : *Le cadeau lui a plu*
My sister looks like me : *Ma soeur me ressemble*

- with *penser* & all reflexive verbs: **à moi, à toi, à lui, à elle, à nous, à vous, à eux, à elles**

I was thinking about him : *Je pensais à lui*

When translating `WHICH' or `WHOM' with the verbs listed above distinguish between PEOPLE and THINGS

i) (referring to people) WHOM : **à qui**

The people she was thinking about : *Les gens à qui elle pensait*
M.Lebrun is the one I want to please : *M. Lebrun est celui à qui je veux plaire*

ii) (referring to things) WHICH : **auquel/à laquelle** (sing) ; **auxquels/auxquelles** (pl)
[takes the number and gender of the noun to which it is referring]

They're not the results I was expecting: *Ce ne sont pas les résultats auxquels je m'attendais*
The temptation I had to resist : *La tentation à laquelle j'ai dû résister*

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87 TO THINK OF / TO THINK ABOUT

i) **penser de** if the meaning is to have an opinion of
What did you think of the film? : *Qu'est-ce que vous avez pensé du film?*
What did you think of it? : *Qu'est-ce que vous en avez pensé?*

i) **penser à** if the meaning is to reflect on
He was thinking of the accident : *Il pensait à l'accident*
He was thinking of it : *Il y pensait*

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